

IN CONTEXT

Stalag VIIIA

The first performance of the Quartet for the End of Time took place in a prisoner-of-war camp, located near Görlitz, in the easternmost part of Germany. Conditions were grim: 30,000 men were crammed into a space that was meant for half that number; it was bitterly cold; and food was scarce—the prisoners survived on a thin stew of potatoes, cabbages, and turnips. Fortunately, though, the camp commandant was sympathetic, allowing Messiaen writing materials. The four-man orchestra played initially in the washrooms, while the Quartet itself was staged in the hut that was used as a theater.



A PERFORMANCE OF QUARTET FOR THE END OF TIME IN 2010